

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 967

By Pody

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Master Sergeant
Roderick "Roddie" W. Edmonds, United States
Army, Medal of Honor recipient.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pride in honoring those courageous Tennesseans whose valor and devotion to duty have brought honor to this State and to the United States of America; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy Tennessean was the late Master Sergeant Roderick "Roddie" W. Edmonds, United States Army, of Knoxville, who, on March 2, 2026, was posthumously awarded the Medal of Honor, the highest military decoration awarded by the United States government; and

WHEREAS, the Medal of Honor is conferred only upon members of the United States Armed Forces who distinguish themselves through conspicuous gallantry and intrepidity at the risk of life above and beyond the call of duty; and

WHEREAS, born on August 20, 1919, in South Knoxville, Master Sergeant Edmonds served with the Regimental Headquarters Company of the 422nd Infantry Regiment, 106th Infantry Division, United States Army, during World War II; in December 1944, he was captured during the Battle of the Bulge and held as a prisoner of war at Stalag IX-A in Ziegenhain, Germany; and

WHEREAS, as the senior noncommissioned officer among approximately 1,200 American prisoners of war, Master Sergeant Edmonds demonstrated extraordinary courage and leadership when a Nazi commander ordered that only Jewish-American prisoners report for roll call, seeking to systematically remove them from the general population to send them to their certain death in Nazi concentration camps; and

WHEREAS, fully aware that such segregation would lead to the persecution and death

of more than 200 Jewish-American soldiers, Master Sergeant Roddie Edmonds directed all 1,200 American prisoners to stand together in formation and refused to identify any Jewish prisoners, famously declaring to the commander, "We are all Jews here!"; and

WHEREAS, when the Nazi commander placed a pistol against his forehead and demanded compliance, Master Sergeant Edmonds stood his ground and warned that executing prisoners of war would constitute a violation of the Geneva Convention and a war crime; the officer ultimately relented, and no Jewish prisoners were identified; and

WHEREAS, by his fearless leadership, moral courage, and unwavering devotion to his fellow soldiers, Master Sergeant Roddie Edmonds saved the lives of more than 200 American servicemen and upheld the highest traditions of military service; and

WHEREAS, his prisoner of war camp was liberated March 30, 1945, and Sergeant Edmonds returned to Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, Master Sergeant Edmonds passed away on August 8, 1985, having never sought recognition for his heroic actions; over time, the story of his bravery was shared by other American prisoners of war and on February 10, 2015, Yad Vashem, The World Holocaust Remembrance Center, recognized Master Sergeant Roddie Edmonds as Righteous Among the Nations, the official title awarded on behalf of Israel to non-Jewish individuals who risked their lives to save Jewish lives during the Holocaust; and

WHEREAS, Sergeant Edmonds is one of only five Americans to be named as Righteous Among the Nations and the only one to also be a Medal of Honor recipient; and

WHEREAS, this General Assembly takes great pride in honoring the memory of Master Sergeant Roddie Edmonds, recognizing the extraordinary courage and character he displayed while a prisoner of war during World War II; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH
GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF

REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Master Sergeant Roderick "Roddie" W. Edmonds and commend his extraordinary heroism and leadership, which saved the lives of his fellow soldiers and for which he was posthumously awarded the Medal of Honor, the nation's highest military decoration.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.